Strapi Plans & API Usage Reference

Complete breakdown of CMS license plans, Strapi Cloud hosting tiers, API request counting, and overages — as of November 2026. For the Meridian project context: **your Strapi is self-hosted Community Edition on Render — unlimited API calls, no meter**.

1. Two separate things get priced

Strapi pricing has **two independent axes**. Mixing them up is the most common confusion:

CMS License = the software features you unlock (free Community, paid Growth / Enterprise). Applies the same whether you self-host or use Strapi Cloud.

Strapi Cloud = managed hosting — servers, DB, CDN, backups. Optional; you can self-host for free (what this project does on Render).

2. CMS License Plans

Community

Free forever

- MIT open-source license
- **Unlimited** content entries
- **Unlimited** API calls
- **Unlimited** locales, roles, components
- REST + GraphQL APIs, API tokens
- RBAC, Draft & Publish, Media Library
- Webhooks, CRON, Custom Fields, Blocks editor
- Static Preview, MCP server, i18n

Growth

$45 / mo

- Everything in Community
- 3 users included (+$15/mo per extra)
- Live Preview
- Releases
- Content History (14 days)
- Strapi AI Growth — 1,000 credits/mo (extra $1.50 per 100)
- Basic Support (license/billing only)
- SSO add-on: $150/mo + $50/user

Enterprise

Custom

- Everything in Growth
- SSO included (SAML/OAuth2)
- Review Workflows
- Audit Logs
- Extended Content History
- SOC 2 report
- Standard Support + Premium options
- Strapi AI Enterprise add-on (bring your own model)
- Offline license option

Growth trial: self-hosted projects can try Growth features free for 30 days, no card required.

3. Strapi Cloud Hosting Plans

Note: The Cloud Free plan and free trial were **discontinued in August 2026**. The cheapest entry is now Starter at $35/mo. (This is exactly why your Render deployment was the right call.)

Starter

$35 / mo

- **100k** API requests / mo
- 50 GB asset storage
- 50 GB asset bandwidth / mo
- Unlimited DB entries*
- 1 environment
- Built-in email, global CDN, custom domain
- **Sleeps when idle**
- Observability 7d, logs 7d

Pro best value

$90 / mo

- **1M** API requests / mo
- 250 GB asset storage
- 500 GB asset bandwidth / mo
- Multi-environment
- Weekly + manual backups (1 mo)
- CRON jobs
- **Always on**
- Observability 30d, logs 14d

Business

$450 / mo

- **10M** API requests / mo
- 1,000 GB asset storage
- 1,000 GB asset bandwidth / mo
- 2 environments included
- Daily backups (1 mo)
- 99.9% uptime SLA
- DDoS protection
- Observability 60d, logs 30d

- **API request overage:** +$1.50 per additional 25,000 requests (billed monthly).
- **Extra environments:** Pro +$60/mo (or $600/yr); Business +$300/mo (or $3,000/yr).
- **Yearly billing:** 20% discount on all paid plans; usage quotas still reset monthly.
- **CMS plan not included:** Cloud hosting covers infrastructure only — Growth/Enterprise features still require a separate CMS license key.

4. What counts as an "API request"

On Strapi Cloud, metering works like this:

COUNTED AS API REQUESTS	NOT COUNTED AS API REQUESTS
• Every request to the **REST API** (`/api/*`) — GET, POST, PUT, DELETE • Every request to the **GraphQL API** • **All response types count** — 200s, errors, empty results	• File & media asset requests (`/uploads/*`) — those count toward **asset bandwidth/storage** instead • Admin panel traffic (`/admin` , `/content-manager`)

Quota resets monthly (even on annual plans). Hitting limits on paid plans triggers overage billing; projects are only suspended for unpaid invoices or plan violations.

5. What this means for the Meridian project

EVENT ON YOUR SITE	STRAPI API REQUESTS
Reader opens a cached article page	**0** — served from Vercel's ISR edge cache
Cache miss / page rebuild	~4–5 (article, related, settings, nav)
View counter on article view	1 (always a live POST)
Newsletter / contact submission	1
Sitemap / RSS regeneration	~3
Admin panel usage	Admin API — uncounted even on Cloud
Images loading	0 — served by Cloudinary

Your actual exposure: self-hosted Community Edition on Render = **no cap at all**. But even if you moved to Cloud Starter's 100k/mo plan, the ISR architecture means typical usage would be a few hundred requests/day — mostly view-counter POSTs, not page views.

6. Decision guide

SITUATION	RECOMMENDED

Demo / portfolio / personal blog	**Community + self-host** (Render/Neon/Cloudinary free tiers — your current setup, $0/mo)
Want managed hosting, low traffic	Community + **Cloud Starter** $35/mo
Real production traffic, backups, no sleep	Community + **Cloud Pro** $90/mo, or self-host on a paid VPS
Editorial team needs Live Preview, Releases, Content History	Add **Growth** license $45/mo on top of either hosting choice
Compliance needs: SSO, audit logs, SLA	**Enterprise** + Cloud Business — talk to sales

Sources: strapi.io/pricing-cms, strapi.io/pricing-cloud, docs.strapi.io/cloud/getting-started/usage-billing (accessed Nov 2026). Prices exclude local taxes. * "Unlimited" entries subject to fair-use/storage plan limits.